

Internal consulting

A practical guide to working with the client and your own management line. Use it to make responsibilities, authority, and capacity explicit before you absorb their contradictions yourself.

S1 Agree the relationships

An internal consultant belongs to the organisation they are helping. They work vertically through management and laterally across colleagues and client services. Familiarity gives context and access, but it can also make assumptions invisible and challenge costly.

The assignment client and your line manager may expect different things. Make a three-way agreement between consultant, client, and manager. Where a separate person commissions, funds, or authorises the work, add that role explicitly. A contracting triangle or rectangle is a practical map, not a complete account of everyone affected.

Relationship	Agreement needed
You and the assignment client	Purpose, work, mutual requirements, access, participation, day-to-day decisions, and review.
You and your line manager	Capacity, priorities, professional boundaries, support, and the route for resolving conflicts.
Your manager and the client	Authority to commission, resource commitments, relative priorities, and changes to the assignment.
A separate sponsor or commissioner	Their decisions, resources, vetoes, and relationship with the day-to-day client. Add a fourth role only when it clarifies the actual arrangement.

Ask who is missing

Who experiences the effects of this work? Who must act on it? Who could prevent it? Staff, residents, partners, assurance functions, and senior decision makers may sit outside the initial contract. Decide how their knowledge and authority will enter.

S2 Agree the work and its conditions

Settle the following with the people who can actually commit. Different parties may hold different authority; equal participation does not mean equal power.

Area	Questions to settle
Purpose and use	What are we trying to make possible, for whom? Which decision or action will use the work?
Outputs and learning	What will be produced? What needs to be understood? What is outside scope?
Contribution	What does each party want, offer, and need? Which conditions are essential, and which can change?
Access and participation	Who and what must be accessible? Who protects the time? What happens if access is unavailable?
Capacity and priority	How much time is allocated? Which existing work is displaced? Who resolves competing demands?
Authority and vetoes	Who decides, pays, implements, and can say no even if the immediate client agrees?
Information	What can be shared with whom? What confidentiality can you genuinely offer?
Review and ending	When do we review progress and the relationship? Who can change scope, pause, escalate, or end the assignment?

Separate your roles

You may be an adviser in one conversation and an assurance professional or manager in another. Name the role you are taking and the responsibilities you cannot set aside. Avoid offering confidentiality or discretion that your other duties prevent you from honouring.

Shared responsibility

The consultant owns the quality and honesty of their contribution. The client owns decisions and actions within their authority. Both contribute to making the relationship usable. Block's 50/50 language challenges over-responsibility; it does not divide tasks or formal accountability into equal halves.

S3 Recontract when the pattern changes

A familiar example

Your manager has allocated two days a week. The service sponsor assumes that you are available whenever needed. You cover the difference to keep the relationship working. That hides the conflict and makes you the place where it accumulates.

A possible opening

'We currently have two different assumptions about my availability. With the time allocated, I can complete the discovery and bring options to a decision meeting. I cannot also lead implementation. Can the three of us agree the priority, capacity, and responsibility for the next stage?'

Prepare the conversation

1. Describe the agreement and what has changed, using observable examples.
2. Explain the effect on the quality, purpose, or feasibility of the work.
3. Ask for the other parties' accounts. Check what you may have missed.
4. Offer choices with their consequences: change access, scope, time, resources, or ownership.
5. Agree who decides, record the decision, and set a review point.

A four-line prompt

I was asked to _____.

The useful work may be _____.

I can take responsibility for _____.

I need the client to take responsibility for _____.

Preserve room to act

Internal consultants cannot always leave the organisation. They may still narrow the task, refuse an unsupported claim, seek a different sponsor, document a limitation, or ask management to resolve a priority conflict. Be realistic about power and use peer support or supervision. Agency is not an instruction to ignore risk.

Basis and further practice

Benjamin P Taylor's synthesis of the 2023 and 2026 internal consulting teaching and the September 2026 discussion, drawing on Peter Block's *Flawless Consulting* and Barry Oshry's account of systemic position. Use the accompanying editable worksheet on one live assignment.